UK Data Service

Advocating for a Data Squad model

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I'm Deb Wiltshire and I'm the Data Access Services Manager at the UK Data Service. It's my job to oversee the teams responsible for data access and use.
Part of our service is an online helpdesk via which people can contact us with any questions they might have. We have around 23,000 students and researchers registered with us, and we have over 8000 datasets in our catalogue. As you can imagine we get a lot of data related queries and keeping up with the volume of these queries is a real challenge!

Our Teams….

Access

User Support & Training

Before I talk about the challenges, I want to introduce our wonderful teams. Data Access Services consists of two teams – the Access Team and the User Support and Training Team
(pics of both)
The Access team – mostly graduates (undergraduates & some with Masters), they have a lot of expertise in applying for data access & data governance issues and they support researchers applying for the data sources we hold.
The UST – mostly PG – masters and doctoral level, so the team come from research backgrounds so have research experience and data skills.

Challenge No1: Data Skills Recruitment

* We have some data skills but only in a few members of the team – the Access Team generally don't join us with data skills so their involvement with data related queries is minimal
* For those User Support & Training team members that do have a research background, their research tends to stop when they join the Service. So the skill set gets rusty over time, and as new statistical and programming software comes out, we don't have those skills in the team

* The good news is that there is real interest and desire in the team to upskill. We have some great people who are keen to develop their own skills and to seek career progression
* The bad news is that time is not on our side – there simply isn't enough hours in the day! The teams are already swamped with work so finding time to train can be challenging.

* In the UST team we tend to recruit from active researchers but the job doesn't offer a research component so we find it difficult to recruit for these posts & we also find staff retention difficult.

* It takes time and effort to fully train up someone for the UST team, and we get at best 1-2 years service out of each appointment so it’s not a sustainable model over time. For those that do stay, they’re not actively carrying out research so we risk the team getting deskilled.

Challenge No2:

We have quantitative and qualitative research skills in UST

BUT we don't offer any research support

- We have quantitative and qualitative research skills in the UST BUT we don't offer any research support
- And this is a shame as many of the queries we receive are research related. Whether that's a student needing advice on weighting their data or a researcher wanting advice on their data cleaning strategies.

* We treat these as outside our remit & usually advise them to contact their supervisors or colleagues for guidance. However, we know that very often they don't have access to supervisors that have the skills to help them – that's why they come to us!
* We also get requests for ready made statistics from organisations – television production companies, small charities, etc. – who may just want a few statistics but don't have the skills within their teams.
* So these is a need for research or statistical consultancy services

The short answer is yes we could! But in our current model, this doesn't work well. At the university we have a scheme called FrontRunners. This allows university departments to host a number of short-term student placements. Placements can run for around 12 weeks, usually in the summer break. We have had a number of Front Runners in the past and they have been fantastic! They bring such a fresh set of ideas and skills that we have really benefitted from. For example the other year, we had a student from the School of Computer Science who worked on a project with us for VR data visualization. It was great to see what he was able to produce in such a short time – he developed an amazing programme that enabled us to put on VR headsets and walk through a dataset. We could produce tables and graphs and move these about and explore them just be moving our hands.

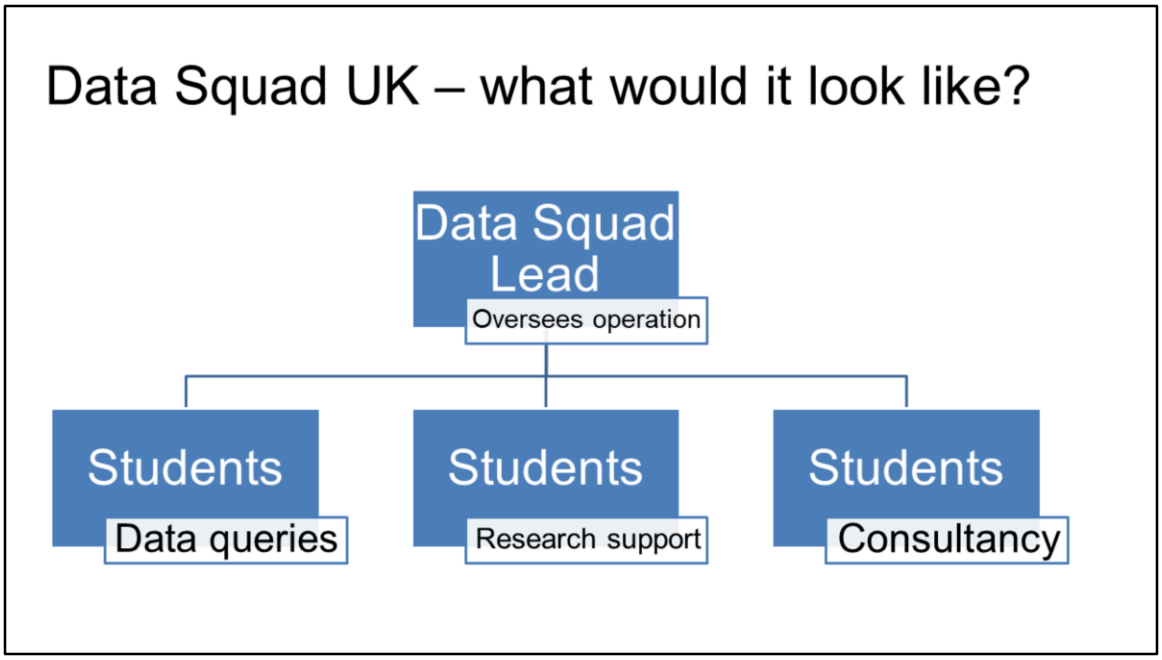
But the boundaries of the scheme does place limits on what we can achieve with student labour. So the placements can only last 12 weeks, they can only be part time and they must be focused on a specific project – we cannot ask students to undertake day to day tasks – which is where we really need the help!

So could the Data Squad model offer a solution?

https://www.accenture.com/gb-en/data-skills-taskforce

1. It would allow us to be more responsive in how we manage our workloads – we can adjust the level of staffing within the teams more quickly and easily.
* Demand for our services fluctuates across the year, we might not be able to justify recruiting when we know we don't always need another long term team member. If we're hit with a sudden increase (e.g. a sharp increase in data queries as undergraduate dissertation deadlines approach), it'll be quicker to bring in additional student support than to recruit salaried staff.
* This would help us avoid periods of increased pressure on the teams – trying to manage the workloads places a lot of stress of the teams and during times of increased demand for services, mental health suffers. Being able to quickly bring in additional resource would help enormously with this
* It would free up time for our permanent team members to do their own training and development
* It would allow us to extend the service we offer – to better meet the demand of the students & researchers that get in touch with us
* Students receive training on the latest techniques and software – so bringing in current students will help ensure that we have current skills available to us

But it’s not just us who will benefit!
* Students would receive ‘on the job’ training, and will gain valuable work experience which will enhance their CV and improve their job prospects. At the end of the day, you can learn the theory of data and research skills, but real life experience teaches us the things that books don’t – like the messiness of real life data, how much time data cleaning really takes, etc.
* Students would get experience in data curation, data management, data access and governance – the parts of the data lifecycle that often doesn’t get taught
* We would be training up the next generation of data professionals – this must be a priority for our sector. I have colleagues and contacts across many different data organisations in the UK and many other data services struggle to recruit – especially for controlled data professionals - as the pool of candidates with skills in data curation, governance, management, confidentiality etc. is quite small.
* There are good careers to be had in the data world – we just need to get that message out to students!



Data Squad Lead – oversees the students, and ensures everything runs smoothly
Data Squad crew –
- students from different disciplines, - just from Essex, or across the UK?
- triaging all data queries
- Respond to queries on data content
- Respond to queries for data cleaning
- Providing research consultancy
- Providing statistical consultancy

Where are we now?

* This has been a process of slowly drip feeding the idea to senior management
* This is a big change! Potentially one of the biggest changes we've seen
* BUT no one has recoiled in horror so far and there's been some signs of enthusiasm – which is all the encouragement I need!
* Just been given the go ahead to put forward a proposal to senior management so some signs of progress!

Questions

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